

# “Animal Farm” by George Orwell [B2]

In questo celebre romanzo breve, Orwell lancia una dura critica al totalitarismo staliniano, trovando l'allegoria perfetta in una stalla governata da maiali.

---

George Orwell (1903-1950) began his writing career in the early 1930s documenting the [plight](#) of the poor and the unemployed in England in articles, [essays](#) and books. In 1936, he moved to Barcelona to fight for the Republicans against Franco's Nationalists in Spain's Civil War. A convinced socialist, he was horrified by the murderous activities of Stalinist communists in Barcelona, and recounted his experiences in his memoir, *Homage to Catalonia* (1938). The rise of fascist and communist dictatorships, and his time in Spain, were the inspiration for *Animal Farm*: A [Fairy Story](#).

## POLITICAL ALLEGORY

*Animal Farm* is a powerfully-written attack on totalitarianism, specifically Stalinism, in the form of a political allegory. It has a quintessentially English setting, a traditional farm. In the late 1930s and early 1940s, many people in the Western world considered that the Soviet communist system was a good example to follow. Orwell disagreed and was worried that this attitude would stop democratic socialism flourishing in the West. He decided to write a story satirising the Russian Revolution of 1917 and the replacement of the Tsarist system of government by a Stalinist autocracy. Orwell knew the horrific reality of life in Stalin's Russia. His experiences in Spain had given him first-hand experience.

## ANIMAL FREEDOM

The book opens with the anthropomorphic animals [seizing](#) their freedom from the corrupt farmer, Mr. Jones — representing the Russian Tsar —, under the leadership of two young [boars](#), Napoleon and Snowball. They hope to create a free and equal society, independent of human intervention. The

farm's pigs are the intellectuals leading the revolution. Soon, however, the first signs of a new hierarchy start to appear. The pigs begin to take special privileges for themselves, starting with [windfall apples](#), now [plentiful](#) on the ground. World

George Orwell e la sua riflessione sull'inglese: "Scrivere o anche solo parlare inglese è un'arte. Chi scrive in inglese è coinvolto in una lotta che non cessa nemmeno per una frase" Dietro le pagine di Orwell non c'è solo la forza delle sue visioni distopiche, ma anche una lezione sul potere delle parole e della lingua inglese. Lo scrittore ci invita a pensare e riflettere con chiarezza per poter scrivere nel miglior modo possibile. Julia Nigmatullina "The animals had assumed as a matter of course that these would be shared out equally; one day, however, the order went forth that all the windfalls were to be collected and brought to the harness-room for the use of the pigs." "Gli animali avevano dato per scontato, come una cosa naturale, che questi frutti sarebbero stati ripartiti in maniera eguale; un giorno, però, fu emanato l'ordine che tutti i frutti fatti cadere dal vento venissero raccolti e portati nella selleria, per essere destinati ai maiali."

## **HUNGER FOR POWER**

Worse is to come as the power-hungry pig Napoleon — representing Stalin but also emblematic of dictatorial power — starts to take control. Napoleon decides that all farm questions will be decided by a committee of pigs, presided over by himself. The other animals are not happy. [Squealer](#), the pig who has become Napoleon's [mouthpiece](#), tells them that: "No one believes more firmly than Comrade Napoleon that all animals are equal. He would be only too happy to let you make your decisions for yourselves. But sometimes you might make the wrong decisions, comrades, and then where should we be?" "Nessuno crede più fermamente del Compagno Napoleone che tutti gli animali siano uguali. Egli sarebbe felicissimo di lasciare che voi prendiate da soli le vostre decisioni. Ma a volte potreste prendere le decisioni sbagliate, compagni, e a quel punto dove finiremmo?"

## EXECUTIONS

Napoleon then increases his power by criticising and attacking Snowball (who represents the intellectual revolutionary Leon Trotsky) with invented stories. Snowball has to flee the farm. Animals accused of helping Snowball in plots are killed by Napoleon's dogs, his protectors (the secret police who enforced Stalin's infamous purges.) "Whenever anything went wrong it became usual to attribute it to Snowball [...] And so the tale of confessions and executions went on, until there was a pile of corpses lying before Napoleon's feet and the air was heavy with the smell of blood."

"Ogniqualvolta qualcosa andasse storto divenne usuale attribuirne la colpa a Palla di Neve. [...] E così la storia delle confessioni e delle esecuzioni andò avanti, finché non ci fu un mucchio di cadaveri ai piedi di Napoleone e l'aria divenne piena dell'odore di sangue."

## A CULT OF LEADER

Napoleon's position becomes unassailable when he introduces a cult of leader, or personality. The praise and flattery become ludicrous, with the hens crediting Napoleon for their laying "five eggs in six days," and the cows in ecstasy because the leader has made the farm's water taste delicious. "Napoleon was now never spoken of simply as 'Napoleon'. He was always referred to in formal style as 'our leader Comrade Napoleon', and the pigs liked to invent for him such titles as Father of All Animals, Terror of Mankind, Protector of the Sheep-fold, Ducklings' Friend, and the like [...] It had become usual to give Napoleon the credit for every successful achievement and every stroke of good fortune." "Ora non si parlava mai di Napoleone chiamandolo semplicemente "Napoleone". Si faceva riferimento a lui sempre in modo formale chiamandolo "il nostro Capo, il Compagno Napoleone", e ai maiali piaceva inventare dei titoli per lui come "Padre di tutti gli animali", "Terrore del genere umano", "Protettore dell'ovile", "Amico degli anatroccoli" e cose del genere.[...] Era diventato consueto attribuire a Napoleone il merito per ogni risultato positivo e per ogni colpo di fortuna."

## BETRAYING THE REVOLUTION

The Russian Revolution was intended to eliminate the capitalist class system, but it only replaced it with another hierarchy. In *Animal Farm*'s final pages, the pigs start walking on two legs and wearing clothes. They even reach agreements with local farmers. Orwell's fable ends with the betrayal of the animals' revolution. "All animals are equal but some are more equal than others" is Napoleon's final [decree](#), before inviting the local farmers for a game of cards. Outside in the [yard](#), the animals watch the game through the farmhouse window. Inside, an [argument](#) begins. "Twelve voices were shouting in anger, and they were all alike. No question, now, what had happened to the faces of the pigs. The creatures outside looked from pig to man, and from man to pig, and from pig to man again; but already it was impossible to say which was which." "Dodici voci stavano urlando piene di rabbia, ed erano tutte simili. Ora non c'era nessun dubbio su cosa fosse successo ai volti dei maiali. Le creature che stavano fuori guardavano prima i maiali e poi gli uomini, e poi gli uomini e poi i maiali, poi ancora i maiali e gli uomini; ma era gi❖❖❖ impossibile distinguerli."

## DEMOCRATIC PROTESTS

*Animal Farm* [made Orwell a household name](#) and an international figure. Since its publication, it has never been [out of print](#). But in 1945 it was actually rejected by many publishers as Russia at that time was an important ally in the war against Nazi Germany. However, with the beginning of the Cold War, the novel would play its part for decades in democratic protests behind the [Iron Curtain](#). This tradition has continued in recent years in countries as diverse as Myanmar, Zimbabwe and Ukraine.

---

# Glossary

- **mouthpiece** = portavoce
- **hens** = galline
- **out of print** = fuori catalogo
- **praise** = elogio
- **seizing** = impossessarsi, conquistare
- **boars** = verri, maschi del maiale
- **flee** = fuggire
- **ludicrous** = ridicoli
- **laying -five eggs** = deporre uova
- **decree** = decreto
- **yard** = cortile
- **made Orwell a household name** = rendere famoso
- **Iron Curtain** = cortina di ferro
- **unassailable** = inattaccabile
- **flattery** = adulazione
- **plight** = difficoltà
- **essays** = saggi
- **windfall apples** = mele cadute dall'albero
- **Squealer** = spione
- **plots** = cospirazioni
- **argument** = discussione
- **Fairy Story** = fiaba
- **plentiful** = abbondanti